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Ethics & Social Responsibility

Lecture Two.

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‘lesson plan’

one

Kantian Ethics

two

Egoism

three

**Aristotelian
Virtue Ethics**

four

Confucianism

KANTIAN ETHICS

overview

**Rationality Must Be
Present in
Morality**

Moral obligations are regardless of
consequences.

Moral obligations arise from a moral
law that is being on all rational beings.

the key to kantian ethics

The intention behind the action is the focus of Kantianism.

- We must intend to do the right thing.

What is the “right thing”?

- The right thing is what satisfies Kant’s two categorical imperatives.

your doctrine:

**“An action is right if it is done with good intentions,
and satisfies the two categorical imperatives –
(a) universalisability and (b) respect for persons.”**

MORE ON CATEGORICAL IMPERATIVES...

kant's categorical imperatives

What even are "categorical imperatives"?

- Kant's categorical imperatives are intended to provide unconditional moral commands that apply to all rational beings.

kant's categorical imperatives

Universalizability

“Act only according to that maxim by which you can at the same time will that it should become a universal law.”

Respect for Persons

“Act so that you treat humanity, whether in your own person or that of another, always as an end and never as a means only.”

let's discuss these in further detail.

categorical imperative one



Universalizability

Individuals must act only on rules (or maxims) that we would be willing to have everyone follow.

- Moral judgments should be universalisable:
 - If an act is right for one person, then as a matter of logical consistency, the act is also “right” for relevantly similar persons in relevantly similar circumstances.

**categorical imperative
one**



What are the implications for moral reasoning?

- “[C]ounters the natural temptation to make exceptions for ourselves or to apply a double standard.”

Poses the common question of “what if everyone did that?”

- Can you think of any examples?

**categorical imperative
one**



Universalizability

**If everyone did it, the proposed action would still be
rational and logical.**

The act cannot be self-contradictory.

categorical imperative two



Respect for Persons

We should respect others and ourselves and their capacity to act freely.

- Can we treat people as a means to an end?
- Why or why not?
- It is “morally appropriate to treat others the way we would like to be treated and not behave as if they were [things]” (Gibson, p. 78).
 - How are humans distinct from “things”?

categorical imperative two



**Respect
for
Persons**

What do you think was Kant's intention for this categorical imperative?

- The proposed action must be consistent with respecting the inherent dignity of people.
- Thus, you cannot use people solely for the purpose of achieving a goal.

Criticisms of Kantian Ethics

The requirement of rationality.

How do we resolve the conflict between two perfect duties?

[Perfect duties are general prohibitions;
for eg, “one must be honest” and “one must not harm others”]

Notes About Kantian Ethics

Do not use “rational” and “moral” interchangeably.

Not all rational actions are moral.

But, all moral actions are rational.

Just something for you to think about.

EGOISM



overview

Ethical Egoism

That individuals ought to act in a self-interested manner.

It simply argues that humans naturally act in our own self-interest,
And that we should do so.

But, that would be too simple.

Central Figures & Strands of Ethical Egoism

one

Niccolo Machiavelli

two

Thomas Hobbes

three

Ayn Rand

one



Machiavelli Egoism

your doctrine:

**An action is right if it is
done to dominate, or
maintain the power to
dominate, others.**

one

Machiavelli Egoism

“We all want to dominate one another.”

- Focus on dominion: the achievement and maintenance of power to dominate others.
- Power is central to success in life, and thus, it is in the individual's self interest to amass power through dominating others by any means necessary.
- The key question is, “What can I get away with?”

Think: Do Machiavelli Egoists help others? Why or why not?

two

**Thomas
Hobbes**

your doctrine:

**Actions done in
cooperation with others
are right if such
cooperation is in the
actor's self-interest
(*ie*, enforced cooperation).**

two

Thomas Hobbes

“We work together to achieve our self-interest; otherwise, we all kill each other.”

- Focuses on enforced cooperation.
 - ie, cooperation with others to maximize welfare because it is in the individual's self-interest to do so.
- No absolute moral standards.
 - Morality is determined by individual preferences and what benefits them in the long-term.
- Examples?

three



Ayn Rand

your doctrine:

**An action is right if
doing it is to act in a
rational manner in one's
self-interest.**

three



Ayn Rand

“Everyone acting in self-interest will bring about maximum happiness.”

- Two conjunctive key points:
 - (1) people should act in their self-interest and, if they do, everything will work itself out; and
 - (2) self-interest is defined as achieving happiness through exercising uncoerced personal choices.
 - In other words, individuals achieve the greatest happiness by having no obligations except the ones that they personally undertake.
 - Rejection of government intervention, eg, imposition of taxes.

three



Ayn Rand

“Everyone acting in self-interest will bring about maximum happiness.”

- To act morally is to act in a rational manner to maximize self-interest.
 - Rationality is a guiding principle of Rand egoism.

three



Ayn Rand

Importance of Rationality in Rand Egoism

- One must be rational in order to determine what is in their true self-interest.
 - *Cf*, acting on whims or instincts.
- One of Rand's key tenets is that valuing and preserving one's own life and happiness is the ultimate goal of Rand Egoism.
 - Thus, considering one's long-term well-being is necessary.

observations about egoism?

Self-Interest does not necessitate acting only for oneself.

Egoists may do things for and help others, because it may ultimately be in their self-interest to do so.

Be sure to understand the nuances between each egoist theory.

Criticisms of Egoism

Machiavelli Egoism

- Do we truly live in a state of mutual animosity? How does being distrusting of everyone square with humans being social creatures?

Hobbes Egoism

- Will society really fall into disarray if we act in self-interested manners?

Rand Egoism

- How exactly would equilibrium and prosperity be achieved?
- With scarce resources, can prosperity be achieved if everyone acted in self-interest?

ARISTOTELIAN --- --- VIRTUE ETHICS

aristotle's virtue ethics

**What are
"Virtue Ethics"?**

Virtue ethics focuses on human character,
actions, or practices.

what are virtues?

generally

**What are
virtues?**

Virtues are “character trait[s] that manifest
[themselves] in habitual action”
(Boatright, p. 62).

what are virtues?

generally

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virtues?

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Examples of Recognised Virtues:

- Benevolence
- Compassion
- Courage
- Courtesy
- Dependability
- Friendliness
- Honesty
- Justice
- Loyalty
- Moderation
- Pride
- Shame
- Toleration

what are virtues?

generally

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What are some common features of these virtues?

- require practice;
- are acquired traits;
- require habitual action; and
- are something we admire in others.

so, what is aristotle's virtue ethics?

"we become just by performing just acts, temperate by performing temperate ones, brave by performing brave ones."

Only the Virtuous are Ethical,
and can live Happy Lives.

A Happy Life is a Good Life.

Whether a "Happy Life" was achieved is based on
the virtuous activities generated over one's
lifetime.

The focus is NOT on
"What goodness is, but how to be good men."

SO,

how do we be good men?

what was Aristotle's focus?

The Achievement of Human Happiness.

A happy man is one who is virtuous throughout his complete lifetime,
(and one who is adequately furnished with external goods - but we will talk about this when discussing Aristotle's theory of distributive justice).

how does Aristotle define “virtue”?

“*purposive* disposition, lying in a *mean* that is *relative to us* and determined by a *rational* principle”

let's break this statement down.

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Aristotle's Definition of Virtue

***“purposive
disposition”***

A “virtue” is a “*purposive disposition*”.

- “[P]urposive” suggests that there must be some kind of mental deliberation - *ie*, voluntariness in the individual’s action.

Aristotle's Definition of Virtue

***“purposive
disposition”***

Before judging whether an action was “good”, or “virtuous”, we must first consider if the act was voluntary.

Aristotle's Definition of Virtue

***“purposive
disposition”***

On Voluntariness: When are acts *involuntary*?

- When the act was done due to/with (1) ignorance of the circumstances and the objects of the act; and (2) the actor suffers subsequent pain and remorse.

OR

- When the act was done under compulsion (*ie*, where the cause of the action is external and the agent contributes nothing to the act).
 - But, duress may not be sufficient, according to Aristotle, to render an act involuntary:
 - *Per* Aristotle, where a tyrant orders a man to do something dishonorable, lest his parents and children be killed, it is datable whether the man's act is considered voluntary or involuntary.

Aristotle's Definition of Virtue

***“purposive
disposition”***

So, what if an action is involuntary?

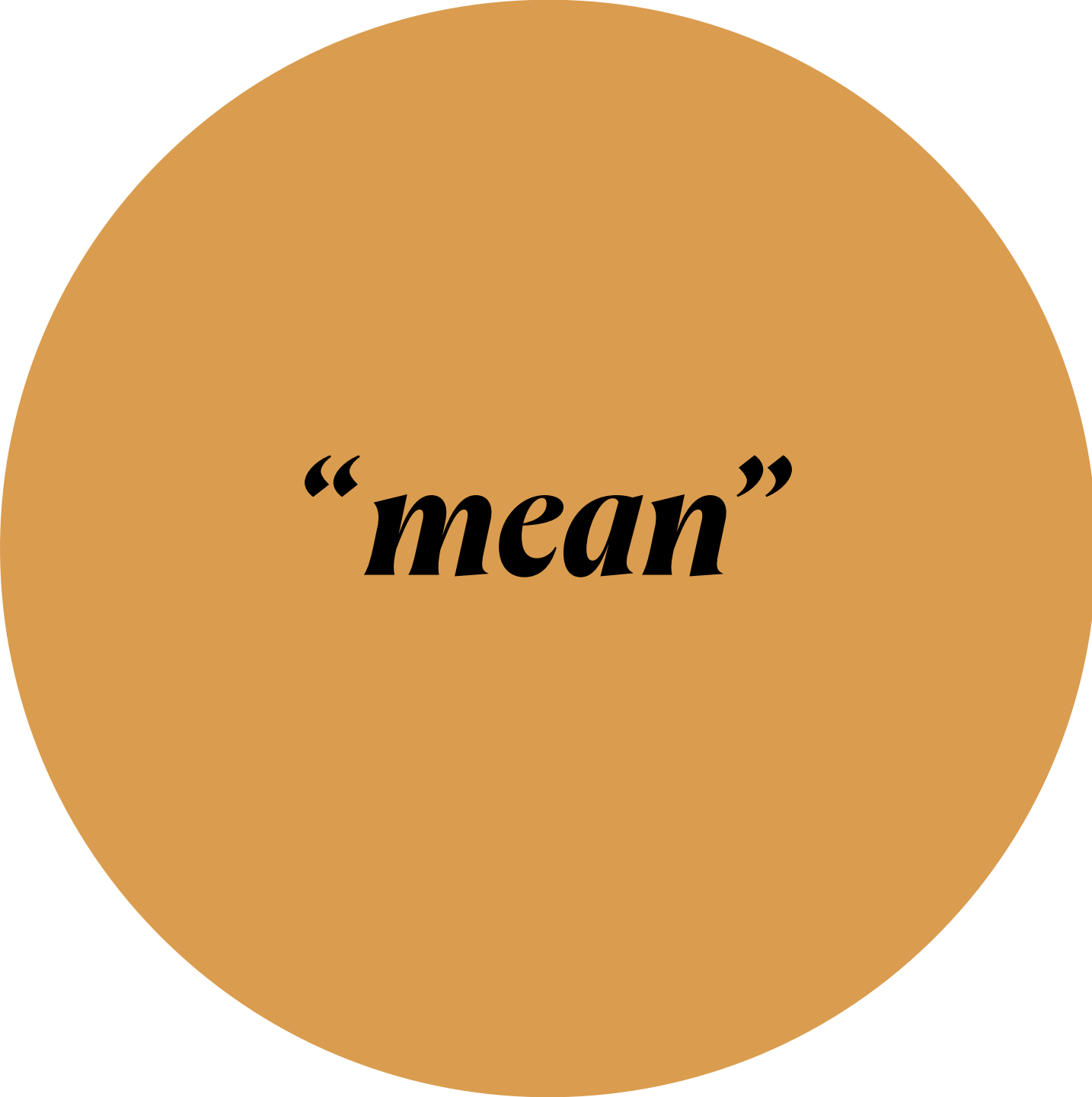
Then, the actor should not be adjudged as being vicious or immoral even if the act harmed another person.

how does Aristotle define “virtue”?

“*purposive* disposition, lying in a *mean* that is *relative to us* and determined by a *rational* principle”

let's break this statement down.

Aristotle's Definition of Virtue

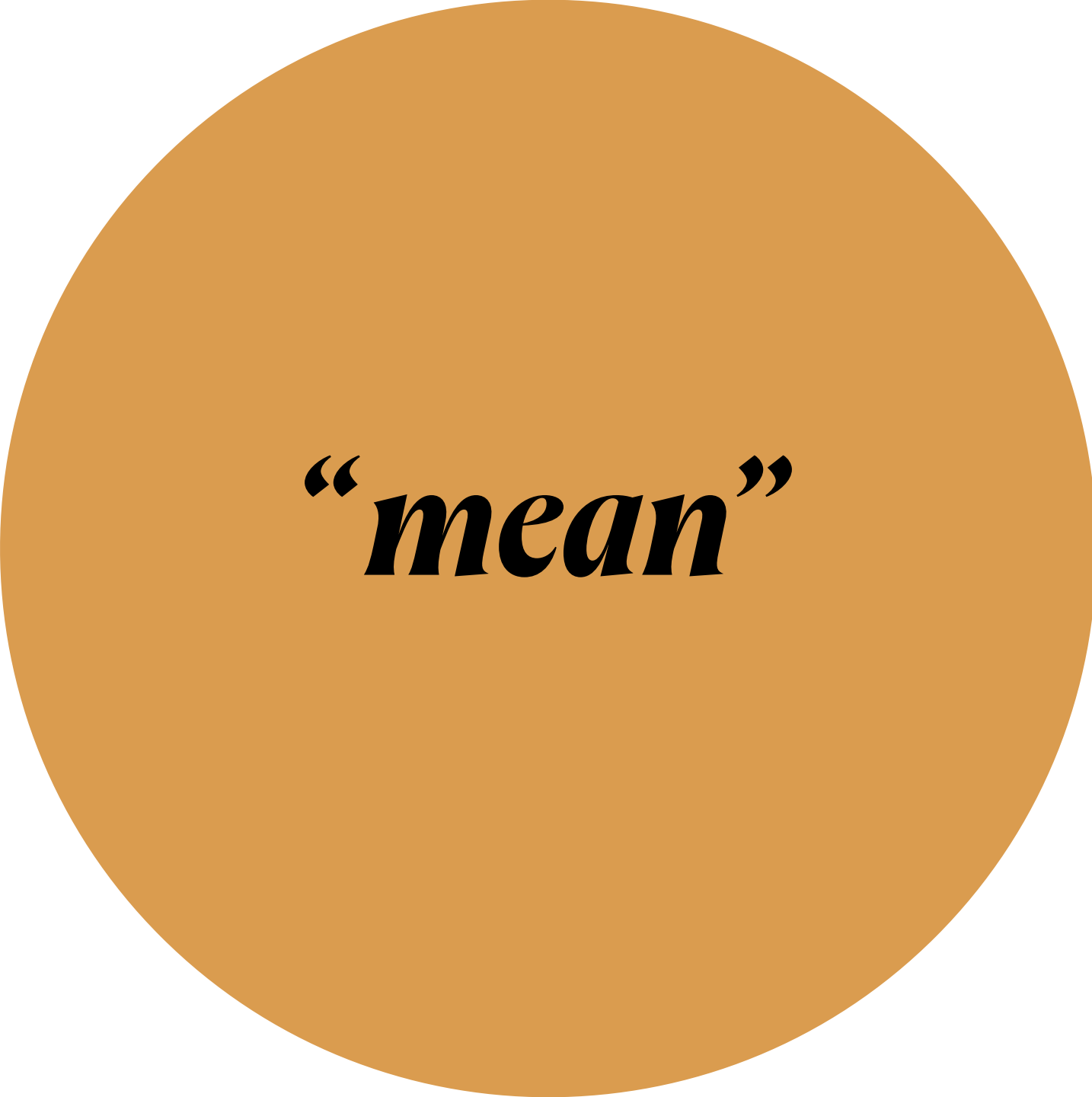


“mean”

What the virtue requires of the actor is dependent on the context.

- It is not about the absolute application of virtues.
- Instead, it is about applying virtues in moderation and proportionately.

Aristotle's Definition of Virtue



“mean”

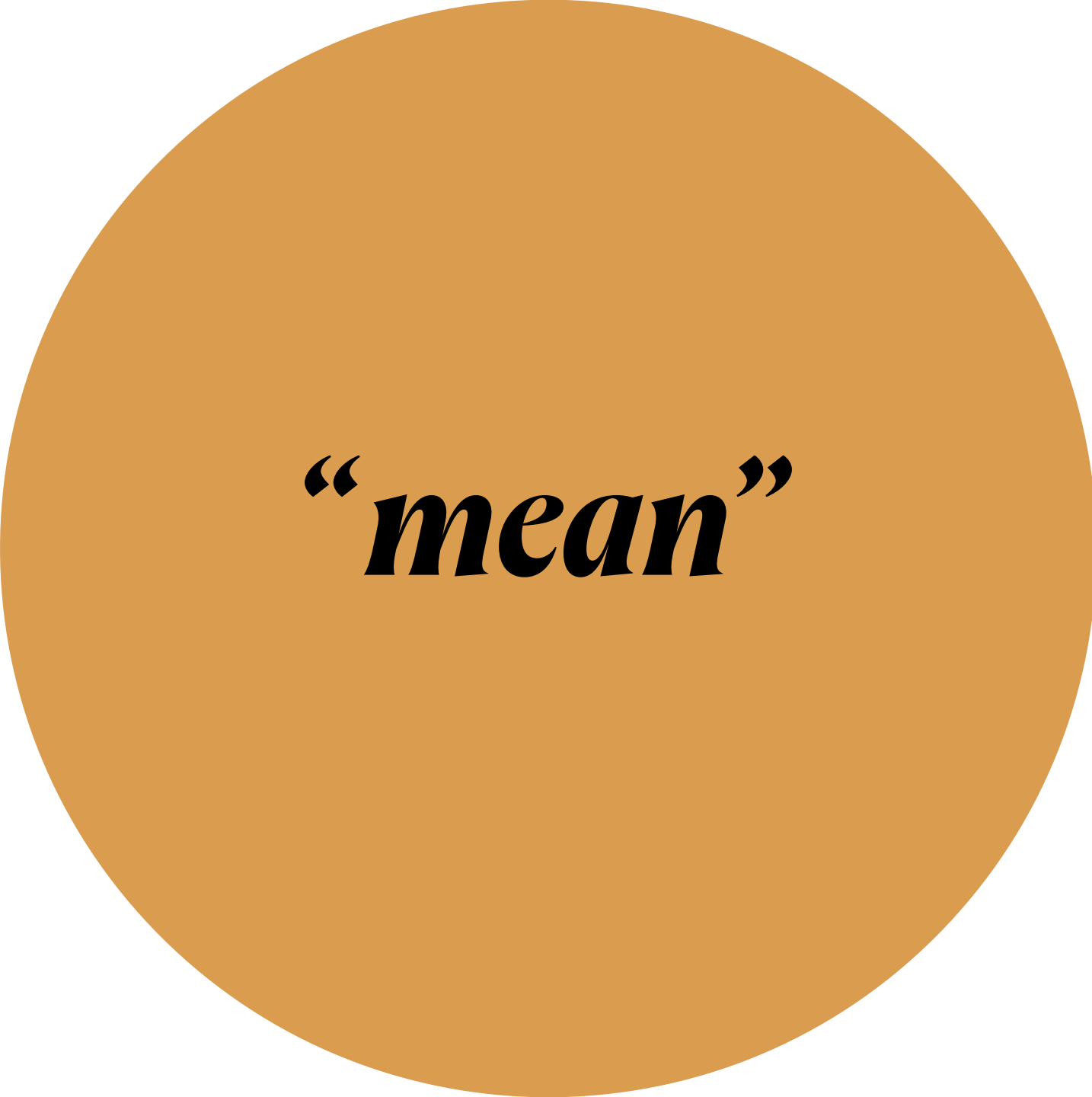
How do we determine the mean?

- Aristotle made reference to some general principles that give guidance but are not instructive:
 - avoid extremes of excess and deficiency;
 - learn from errors; and
 - guard against pleasures which can induce vice.

“Too much confidence is rashness, too little is cowardliness”

“Too much honor is vanity; too little is undue humility.”

Aristotle's Definition of Virtue



“mean”

Criticism: There is insufficient guidance as to how to determine the mean.

- Aristotle himself has admitted that it is difficult for us to consequently achieve the mean.

how does Aristotle define “virtue”?

“*purposive* disposition, lying in a *mean* that is *relative to us* and determined by a *rational* principle”

let's break this statement down.

Aristotle's Definition of Virtue



“relative to us”

The scope of the “virtue” appears to depend on the actor’s relative judgment (as to where the “mean” lies.

- This necessitates that the determination of mean inadvertently imports some relativity and/or subjectivity:
 - ie, what the “mean” is will be determined by a rational person thinking rationally, but will inescapably have elements of their subjective views and interpretations.
- But, any subjectivity and bias that may be imported into determining the mean should be “tempered by the requirement of rationality”.

what about stereotypically bad acts?

Let's think about bad acts like, adultery, theft, or murder (ie, intentional killing; cf. righteous/just killing).

Do you think that these could fall within the mean?

No. They can't.

- Aristotle viewed these actions as evil in and of themselves and, thus, could not be virtuous and were plainly not subject to the mean.

now,

*how can we apply Aristotle's virtue ethics
to the business context?*

why is it so hard to so apply?

Unlike utilitarianism, egoism, and Kantian ethics, Aristotle's virtue ethics (like other theories of virtue ethics) does not offer "direct, normative principles on human conduct.

The focus is instead on character and human attributes.

In other words, it is difficult to apply Aristotle's virtue ethics and determine what is right and wrong in the moment.

Additionally, due to the relativity and subjectivity in determining the "mean", what constitutes the mean may shift over time and/or with societal's views.

but, maybe it is thus, very appropriate for business

Professors Gary Chan and George Shenoy posit that the flexibility, and hence, adaptability, of virtue ethics is consistent with the intuitive judgments required in the business setting.

Cf. unrelenting and strict rules on ethical decision making.

A professional is “good” if he/she/they adopts Aristotle’s approach to virtue ethics.

but, maybe it is thus, very appropriate for business

Business decisions should be made with:

- a commitment to attain human goods;
- to enable us to achieve humanly flourishing lives.

But, “humanly flourishing lives” does not entail having lots of material things.

Aristotle viewed wealth only as a means to happiness; but not as the be all and end all to life.

Criticisms of Aristotle Virtue Ethics

How do we determine the "mean"?

What standard of a virtue do we apply in any situation?

Is "theft" necessarily a stereotypically bad act? Could theft be done virtuously if the purpose of the theft was virtuous?

CONFUCIANISM



overview

What do you know about Confucianism?

Humans are social creatures and “the way we structure communities will necessarily involve reciprocal duties and personal compromises.” (Gibson, p. 153).

- We achieve happiness if we understand our proper place and duties to others.
- Emphasizes individual growth to become a “personal of excellence” (or superior man), someone who is:
 - aware of societal demands of him,
 - is selfless;
 - understands his private life; and
 - is courteous in the public arena.

importance of relationships

Confucianism emphasizes the importance of five relationships:

- Parent-Child
- Husband-Wife
- Elder-Younger Sibling
- Ruler-Subject / Master-Servant
- Elder-Younger Friend

These relationships recognize a hierarchy and natural inequality between individuals that imposes duties on both sides.

Note: If analogizing the employer-employee relationship (which is not on the list above to ruler-subject relationship, you must expressly state that you are doing so and explain why it is appropriate to do so.

the “golden rule”

“Do not do unto others what you do not want others to do unto you”

the “golden rule”

“Do not do unto others what you do not want others to do unto you”

This suggests a key theme of reciprocity in Confucianism.

In *The Great Learning*, Confucius states in the context of the master-servant relationship:

What a man dislikes in his superiors, let him not display in the treatment of his inferiors: what he dislikes in inferiors, let him not display in the service of his superiors.

In the *Analects*:

The Duke of She told Confucius, 'In my country there is an upright man named Kung. When his father stole a sheep, he bore witness against him.'

Confucius said, 'The upright men in my community are different from this. The father conceals the misconduct of the son and the son conceals the misconduct of the father. Uprightness is to be found in this.'

to briefly summarise,

Confucianism demands reciprocity.

But, not equality - *ie*, there is no need to treat all men as equal.

But, this demand of reciprocity is caveated by the moral obligations imposed by familial relationships.

And thus, moral judgments import a “kinship-based subjectivity”.

why does confucianism seem so difficult to apply in most contexts?

In *The Great Learning*, Confucius states:

A man of humanity develops his personality by means of his wealth, while the inhumane person develops wealth at the sacrifice of his personality.

confucianism & business

But, recall that the primary focus of Confucian theories is “the cultivation of virtues, humanity and self-development”.

Confucian theory does not condemn business activities.

- But, it demands that the business activities not be conducted for selfish purposes or be contrary to public good.

in other words,

*Confucianism demands that the sole goal of
business activities **CANNOT** be
profit making or the accumulation of wealth.*

*If so, the business activity would be unethical,
per Confucianism.*

How has Confucianism presented itself in business?

In Japan:

Parent, Sister, and Affiliated Companies are regarded as “Partners” within a Quasi-Family Circle.

Firing employees is akin to disowning a family member.
Similarly, quitting your job is akin to emancipating yourself from your family.

Employees are more likely to be excluded from decision-making.

How has Confucianism presented itself in business?

In China:

The giving of a favour carries an expectation of reciprocity.
Failing which, there is a “loss of face” by the one who gave the favour.

But, are the giving of such favors ethical?

comparing confucianism and other ethical theories

Any thoughts as to the differences between them?

Confucian ethics does not possess a doctrine of rights.

- While individuals in society have duties to observe moral rules, individuals do not have a special right to make claims or complain against each other for breaches of such moral rules.
 - An individual may assert that the wrongdoer has not fulfilled his/her/their duties.
 - But, may not plead that he/she/they have been specifically wronged.

This is reflective of and consistent with the communitarian approach to ethics in Confucianism.

Criticisms of Confucianism

When can we apply Confucianism in our consideration of ethical dilemmas?

Lacking in respect and conferring dignity to individuals whose rights have been infringed?

Misconduct may be virtuous if done in the respect of family relationships
[for eg, it is ethical for a son to conceal the misconduct of his father]

Thank
You.

“

Remember to do right this
week.

But, what does “right”
even mean?

—